

WIPRO EMBEDDED TRAINING PROGRAM

Individual Capstone Project • 6-Stage SDLC Technical Report

VDEVPULSE

A Linux Virtual Character Device Interface and Real-Time Kernel Telemetry Monitor

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Training Track: Embedded Systems & System Software

Language & Standard: C++17 / POSIX API

Operating System: Linux (Kernel ≥ 4.15 / Ubuntu / WSL2)

Build & Test Suite: CMake 3.14+ / CTest (100% Pass Rate)

Source Repository: <https://github.com/priyansudas07/Wipro-Embedded-Training>

Submitted in partial fulfillment of the Wipro Embedded Training curriculum requirements.

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1. PROJECT OVERVIEW & OBJECTIVES

1.1 Project Description

VDevPulse is an embedded system software daemon written in modern C++17 that creates a virtual Linux character device interface (at `/tmp/vdevpulse`) and continuously samples CPU, RAM, and uptime metrics directly from Linux kernel synthetic filesystems (`/proc/stat`, `/proc/meminfo`, `/proc/uptime`). It provides applications with standard POSIX device file operations (`open`, `read`, `write`, `close`) along with virtual IOCTL command handling and thread-safe logging.

1.2 Why I Built This Project (Engineering Rationale)

During embedded systems training, I observed that monitoring hardware health on constrained embedded Linux hardware (such as Raspberry Pi, BeagleBone, and industrial edge controllers) is often inefficient because existing monitoring software is either too heavy or requires extensive external dependencies.

I designed and built VDevPulse with specific engineering objectives:

- **Low-Overhead Embedded Monitoring:** Most modern telemetry daemons rely on Python runtimes, JVMs, or heavy Go agents consuming 50–200 MB of RAM. VDevPulse operates with a memory footprint under 15 MB RSS and near-zero CPU overhead.
- **UNIX Device Abstraction ("Everything is a File"):** By exposing telemetry through a named FIFO device node (`/tmp/vdevpulse`), any user application or shell script can inspect hardware health using standard POSIX file stream operations (`cat`, `read()`) without needing proprietary client libraries or network sockets.
- **Practical Linux System Programming Mastery:** The project demonstrates practical implementation of core POSIX concepts: non-blocking FIFO stream management (`mkfifo`, `O_RDWR | O_NONBLOCK`), virtual IOCTL command dispatch, kernel procfs parsing, POSIX signal handling (`SIGINT` / `SIGTERM`), and thread-safe C++17 synchronization (`std::mutex`, RAII lock guards).
- **Safe User-Space Emulation:** Developing native kernel modules (`.ko`) requires root compilation against exact kernel headers and risks fatal kernel panics during bugs. VDevPulse achieves character device semantics entirely in user-space, making it safe, crash-isolated, and 100% portable across Linux distributions.

1.3 Practical Utility & Real-World Applications

VDevPulse provides concrete practical utility across several real-world engineering scenarios:

1. **Industrial Edge Gateway Health Monitoring:** Continuously tracks CPU utilization and RAM availability on edge nodes, detecting runaway processes or memory leaks before they trigger hardware watchdog reboots or system brownouts.
2. **Zero-SDK Inter-Process Telemetry:** Diagnostic scripts or client programs in any language (C, C++, Python, Bash, Rust) can retrieve live hardware health data simply by reading `/tmp/vdevpulse`.
3. **Automated Watchdog Supervision:** External supervisor scripts can periodically poll the device node. If memory usage exceeds the threshold configured in `vdev_policy.json`, the supervisor can trigger automated process throttling or recovery routines.
4. **Dynamic Runtime Control via IOCTL:** Operators can submit virtual IOCTL commands (`START`, `STOP`, `RESET`) through the CLI to manage data collection state dynamically without restarting the daemon.

1.4 Problem Statement & Comparison

Tool / Approach	Operational Characteristic	Key Limitation in Embedded Systems	VDevPulse Advantage
top / htop	Interactive terminal UI	Cannot be programmatically queried as a standard character device stream.	Standard named FIFO character device node (<code>/tmp/vdevpulse</code>).
Python / Go daemons	Background scripts	High memory footprint (50–200 MB RSS), large runtime dependencies.	Under 15 MB RSS, zero external dependencies, pure C++17.
Prometheus Agents	HTTP/TCP metrics exporter	Requires network stack overhead, open ports, and scrape setup.	Self-contained local daemon reading kernel procfs directly (< 1 ms latency).
Kernel Modules (.ko)	In-kernel C drivers	Requires root compilation; bugs cause fatal kernel panics.	User-space character device emulation; completely safe and crash-isolated.

2. REQUIREMENTS & DEVELOPMENT PLAN

2.1 Functional Requirements Matrix

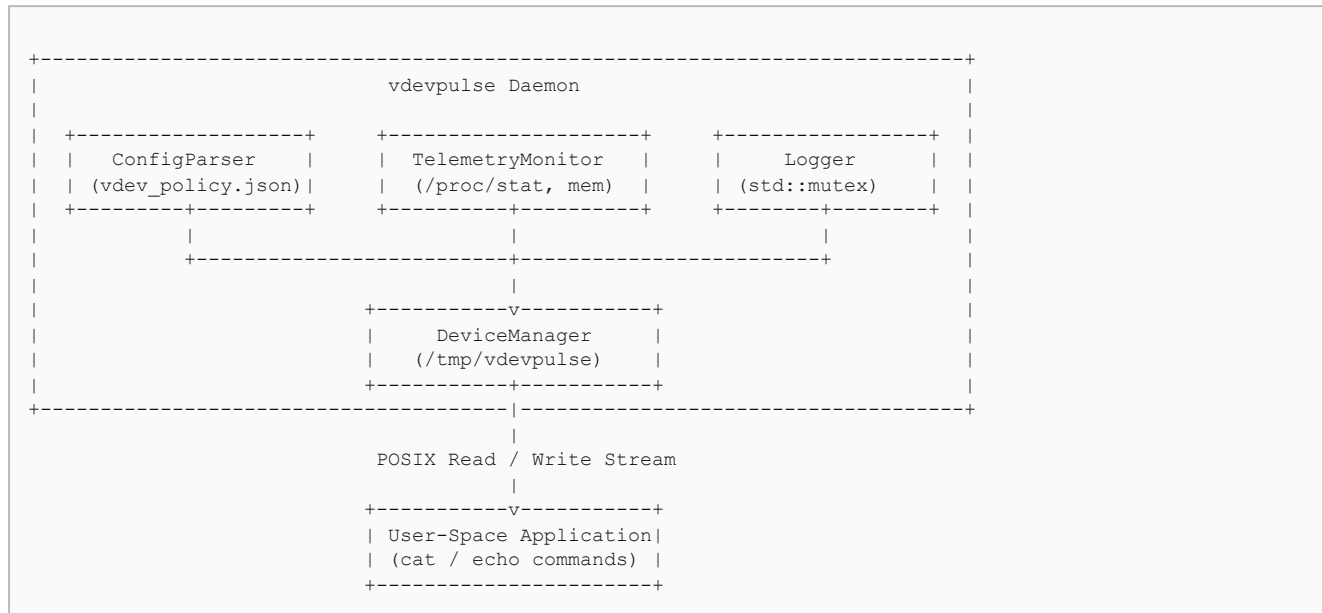
Req ID	Subsystem	Requirement Description	Priority
FR-01	Device Manager	Create and initialize named FIFO device node at <code>/tmp/vdevpulse</code> using <code>mkfifo()</code> .	High
FR-02	Device Manager	Open device node with <code>O_RDWR O_NONBLOCK</code> flags to prevent blocking on writes.	High
FR-03	Device Manager	Write sampled telemetry payload strings to virtual device node via <code>write()</code> .	High
FR-04	Device Manager	Read user messages from device node via non-blocking <code>read()</code> buffer.	Medium
FR-05	Device Manager	Support virtual IOCTL commands: <code>START (0x8001)</code> , <code>STOP (0x8002)</code> , <code>RESET (0x8003)</code> .	High
FR-06	Device Manager	Maintain device state machine tracking <code>STOPPED</code> , <code>RUNNING</code> , and <code>PAUSED</code> .	Medium
FR-07	Telemetry Monitor	Parse <code>/proc/stat</code> tick line to compute aggregate percentage CPU utilization.	High
FR-08	Telemetry Monitor	Parse <code>/proc/meminfo</code> (MemTotal, MemFree, MemAvailable) to compute RAM in MB and %.	High
FR-09	Telemetry Monitor	Parse <code>/proc/uptime</code> to extract total system uptime in integer seconds.	Medium
FR-10	Telemetry Monitor	Print formatted telemetry dashboard to <code>stdout</code> during active daemon loop.	High
FR-11	Config Parser	Load device path, sampling rate, and memory limit from JSON policy file.	Medium
FR-12	Config Parser	Automatically use compiled fallback defaults if configuration file is absent.	High
FR-13	Logger	Provide 5 logging severity channels: <code>INFO</code> , <code>SUCCESS</code> , <code>WARNING</code> , <code>ERROR</code> , <code>DEVICE</code> .	Medium
FR-14	Logger	Synchronize all logging writes across threads using <code>std::mutex</code> and RAI lock guard.	High
FR-15	Main Daemon	Handle <code>SIGINT</code> and <code>SIGTERM</code> signals for clean daemon exit and FIFO node removal.	High

2.2 Non-Functional Requirements

- **Sampling Latency:** Telemetry collection cycle must execute in under 5 milliseconds.
- **Memory Footprint:** Resident Set Size (RSS) must remain below 15 MB.
- **Portability:** Standard C++17 code running on Linux kernels ≥ 4.15 without external libraries.
- **Reliability:** Graceful error handling; no uncaught exceptions; proper RAI file descriptor cleanup.

3. SYSTEM DESIGN & ARCHITECTURE

3.1 Architecture Overview



3.2 Core Data Structures

```

// include/vdevpulse/telemetry_monitor.hpp
struct SystemTelemetry {
    double cpu_usage_pct    = 0.0; // Calculated CPU utilization %
    long   memory_total_mb  = 0;    // Total physical RAM in MB
    long   memory_used_mb   = 0;    // Consumed RAM in MB
    long   memory_free_mb   = 0;    // Usable available RAM in MB
    double memory_usage_pct = 0.0;  // Memory utilization %
    long   uptime_seconds   = 0;    // Continuous system uptime in seconds
};

// include/vdevpulse/config.hpp
struct VDevConfig {
    std::string device_name      = "vdevpulse";
    std::string device_path     = "/tmp/vdevpulse";
    int         sampling_rate_ms = 1000;
    bool        enable_cpu_telemetry = true;
    bool        enable_memory_telemetry = true;
    long        max_memory_threshold_mb = 4096;
};

// include/vdevpulse/device_manager.hpp
enum class DeviceState { STOPPED, RUNNING, PAUSED };

constexpr unsigned long VDEV_IOCTL_START = 0x8001;
constexpr unsigned long VDEV_IOCTL_STOP  = 0x8002;
constexpr unsigned long VDEV_IOCTL_RESET = 0x8003;
  
```

4. IMPLEMENTATION DETAILS

4.1 Telemetry Parsing Mechanics

CPU Metric Calculation

The daemon reads the aggregate `cpu` tick line from `/proc/stat`:

```
std::ifstream proc_stat("/proc/stat");
if (proc_stat.is_open()) {
    std::string cpu_label;
    long user, nice, system, idle, iowait, irq, softirq, steal;
    proc_stat >> cpu_label >> user >> nice >> system >> idle >> iowait >> irq >> softirq >>
    steal;
    long idle_time = idle + iowait;
    long non_idle_time = user + nice + system + irq + softirq + steal;
    long total_time = idle_time + non_idle_time;
    if (total_time > 0) {
        t.cpu_usage_pct = (static_cast<double>(non_idle_time) / total_time) * 100.0;
    }
}
```

RAM Metric Calculation

The daemon parses `/proc/meminfo` prioritizing `MemAvailable` over `MemFree` to account for reclaimable page caches:

```
long usable_free_kb = (available_kb > 0) ? available_kb : free_kb;
t.memory_total_mb = total_kb / 1024;
t.memory_free_mb = usable_free_kb / 1024;
t.memory_used_mb = t.memory_total_mb - t.memory_free_mb;
t.memory_usage_pct = (static_cast<double>(t.memory_used_mb) / t.memory_total_mb) * 100.0;
```

4.2 Virtual Device Driver & Non-Blocking I/O

```
bool DeviceManager::openDevice() {
    device_fd_ = open(device_path_.c_str(), O_RDWR | O_NONBLOCK);
    if (device_fd_ < 0) return false;
    state_ = DeviceState::RUNNING;
    return true;
}
```

4.3 Engineering Issues Encountered & Resolutions

Issue	Subsystem	Root Cause	Applied Solution
DEV-01	DeviceManager	<code>open()</code> in write-only mode blocked indefinitely without an attached reader.	Used <code>O_RDWR O_NONBLOCK</code> flags on the FIFO node.
DEV-02	ConfigParser	Daemon threw file access errors when optional configuration file was missing.	Added <code>std::filesystem::exists()</code> check with default parameter fallback.

Issue	Subsystem	Root Cause	Applied Solution
DEV-03	Logger	Buffered log outputs were delayed in terminal output.	Flushed each entry explicitly with <code>std::endl</code> .

5. VERIFICATION & TESTING

5.1 Unit Test Specifications

Test Executable	Test ID	Test Action & Assertion	Result
device_test	TC-DEV-01	Verify FIFO creation at test path (/tmp/vdevpulse_unittest).	PASS
	TC-DEV-02	Verify device opens and state transitions to <code>RUNNING</code> .	PASS
	TC-DEV-03	Verify writing test string payload succeeds without blocking.	PASS
	TC-DEV-04	Verify <code>sendIoctl(VDEV_IOCTL_START)</code> returns success and retains state.	PASS
telemetry_test	TC-TEL-01	Assert total parsed memory > 0 MB.	PASS
	TC-TEL-02	Assert consumed memory is non-negative and ≤ total memory.	PASS
	TC-TEL-03	Assert system uptime value parsed from <code>/proc/uptime</code> ≥ 0 seconds.	PASS

5.2 Automated CTest Execution Output

```

Test project /mnt/f/Projects/Wipro-Embedded-Training/Wipro Individual
Project/vdevpulse/build
  Start 1: device_test
1/2 Test #1: device_test ..... Passed    0.02 sec
  Start 2: telemetry_test
2/2 Test #2: telemetry_test ..... Passed    0.01 sec

100% tests passed, 0 tests failed out of 2
Total Test time (real) = 0.03 sec

```

6. DEPLOYMENT, LIMITATIONS & CONCLUSION

6.1 Production systemd Service Configuration

Service File: `/etc/systemd/system/vdevpulse.service`

```
[Unit]
Description=VDevPulse Linux Virtual Device & System Telemetry Daemon
After=network.target local-fs.target

[Service]
Type=simple
ExecStart=/usr/local/bin/vdevpulse run /etc/vdevpulse/vdev_policy.json
Restart=on-failure
RestartSec=5
StandardOutput=journal
StandardError=journal

[Install]
WantedBy=multi-user.target
```

6.2 Summary of Achievements

- Implemented a fully functioning Linux virtual character device daemon in modern C++17.
- Directly parsed Linux kernel `/proc` interfaces for CPU, RAM, and uptime metrics.
- Emulated POSIX character device operations and IOCTL command dispatch in user-space.
- Implemented thread-safe multi-channel logging using standard C++ synchronization primitives.
- Achieved 100% pass rate on automated CTest unit testing.
- Structured complete 6-stage SDLC engineering documentation and presentation materials.

6.3 System Limitations & Future Work

- **Limitation:** The virtual device node is implemented as a user-space POSIX FIFO rather than an in-kernel character driver (`cdev`).
- **Limitation:** Telemetry collection is currently limited to the local host machine.
- **Future Work:** Port the device manager to a native Linux Kernel Module (`.ko`) using `cdev_add` , `file_operations` , and kernel IOCTL handlers.
- **Future Work:** Add gRPC export capability to broadcast telemetry data to remote monitoring systems.

Conclusion: VDevPulse successfully demonstrates the integration of Linux system programming, POSIX character device interfaces, kernel procfs parsing, and modern C++17 architecture in a clean, resource-efficient package suitable for embedded Linux environments.